TOPIC 01 · EXCEL FUNDAMENTALS WITH COPILOT
LAB 1 THEME · DATA PREP & DATA QUALITY

Lab 1 — Explore and Question Recruitment Pipeline Data

Maps to	LO1: confirm Copilot access and use the Chat only, Plan and Allow editing modes to prepare, check, highlight, sort and filter recruitment pipeline data
Duration	35 minutes
Tools	Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop) · Copilot (Chat only, Plan, Allow editing, model picker) · BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx
Mock data	data/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx
Course	Microsoft 365 Copilot for Excel (C34) · v3.2
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-1

Goal

Turn a raw candidate-pipeline export into a named Excel table, find and fix its data-quality issues with Copilot, and answer pipeline questions you can check.

What You Will Do

You are a talent analyst at BrightPath Talent Solutions, a fictional Singapore recruitment and staffing firm. You will meet Copilot's three modes on a real task, asking in plain English: Allow editing turns the H1 2026 pipeline export into a named table, Chat only describes it without touching the sheet, and Plan shows you its steps before it fixes duplicate IDs and inconsistent Source names. You will then ask which source brings in the most hires, have Copilot add a Checks sheet to confirm the answer, compare two AI models, and highlight, sort and filter the pipeline.

What You Will Build

BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx in your work-c34 folder with table tblApplications, a Source_Clean column, duplicate IDs and Hired rows highlighted, a Checks sheet that confirms the hire counts and a filled Prompt_Log

Prerequisites

- A Microsoft 365 account with Copilot in Excel enabled, signed in to Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop).
- A folder named work-c34 on your computer for your working copies.
- This lab folder downloaded, including data/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx.

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional BrightPath data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real employees' personal data into Copilot, rules or skills.

Steps

Step 1. Copy BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx from this lab's data folder into a work-c34 folder on your computer and open it in Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop). Work on this local copy - no OneDrive upload is needed. Check that Formulas > Calculation Options is Automatic, then open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab or the floating Copilot icon at the bottom right. Read the About_This_Data sheet before you prompt.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Required state:
File : work-c34/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx (local copy)
Calculation Options : Automatic
Sheets : About_This_Data | Applications | Prompt_Log
```

Step 2. Open Copilot and find the mode menu above the prompt box: Chat only (answers, no changes), Plan (shows its steps first) and Allow editing (makes the changes). Choose Allow editing and ask Copilot to turn the data into a table. Its reply should confirm tblApplications with 13 columns and 242 rows. Select Done to keep the change, or Undo to reverse it. If Excel offers 'Clean data with Copilot', select Dismiss for now - you will use it in Lab 4.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
Turn the data on the Applications sheet into a table named tblApplications. Don't change any
values.
Then tell me how many rows and columns it has.
```

Step 3. Switch to Chat only (no workbook changes) and ask Copilot to describe the data. The row count should match Step 2 (242). If Copilot already mentions odd Source names such as 'Linked In', note them - you fix them in Step 4.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
Describe this data for me. What does one row represent, what dates does it cover, and what are
the different Stage and Source values?
```

Step 4. Still in Chat only, ask Copilot to look for problems. It should find 2 repeated Application_IDs and Source names spelt more than one way ('Linked In', and 'JobStreet' with an extra space). Then switch to Plan and ask for the fix: read Copilot's plan, approve it, then select Done. Each repeated ID turns orange in both places it occurs - one near the top of the table and its copy in the last rows (press Ctrl+End to jump there). To check the fix, open the filter arrow on the new Source_Clean column: you should see 7 sources and no 'Linked In', and the table still has 242 rows.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
Are there any data-quality problems in tblApplications, such as repeated Application_IDs or
Source names spelt in different ways? Don't change anything yet.

PLAN MODE:
Highlight the repeated Application_IDs in orange. Then add a Source_Clean column with the
Source names tidied up, and keep the original Source column as it is.
```

Step 5. Ask Copilot which source brings in the most hires (Chat only). Then switch to Allow editing and ask it to add a Checks sheet that counts the hires with formulas, so you can confirm its answer. Finally, open the model picker at the top of the pane (Auto by default), choose a different model, select New chat and send the first prompt again. Both answers must match the Checks sheet - if a model disagrees, the Checks sheet wins.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
PROMPT (Chat only):
Which source brings in the most hires? Show the applications, hires and hire rate for each
source, using Source_Clean.

CHECK (Allow editing):
Add a Checks sheet with formulas that count the total hires and the LinkedIn hires, so I can
check your answer.
```

Step 6. Stay in Allow editing and send these one change at a time. After each change, look at the sheet and keep it or select Undo in the Copilot pane. When you have the filtered count, select Data > Clear to show all 242 rows again.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
1) Highlight the rows of candidates who were hired in light green.
2) Sort the table so the highest interview scores come first.
3) Show only the Technology candidates at the Interview stage. How many are there?
```

Step 7. Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab with its step and mode. Ask Copilot to fill in what it did, how it was verified and your decision (Keep, Revise or Undo). Save the workbook (Ctrl+S / Cmd+S) when it is done.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
LOG (Allow editing):
Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab. For each one I ran, fill in What Copilot
did and How I verified, and set Decision to Keep. I will tell you any row to change to Revise
or Undo.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Copilot pane (or adapt them). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online:
https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-1

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Summary	Give me a quick summary of this pipeline data in five bullet points.
2	Question	Which sector received the most applications?
3	Question	Which recruiter has the most candidates at the Offer stage?
4	Highlight	Highlight the candidates with an interview score of 5 in light blue.
5	Insight	What's interesting about this data? Give me three observations with the numbers behind them.

Test It

Check	Expected result
Rows in tblApplications	242 rows, 240 unique Application_IDs
Duplicate IDs (orange)	APP-0018 and APP-0020 - 4 orange cells: 2 near the top, 2 in the last rows
Source_Clean	7 sources - 3 'Linked In' and 2 'JobStreet' (extra space) fixed
Hires (Checks sheet)	22 in total; LinkedIn has the most (8)
Two models	Both name LinkedIn as the top source, matching the Checks sheet
Technology + Interview filter	9 rows; all 242 back after Data > Clear

Checkpoint

Keep this workbook in work-c34. Lab 2 uses a separate requisitions workbook, so a learner who is behind can start Lab 2 from its own data folder.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
The Copilot button is missing or greyed out.	Save the file as a normal .xlsx, close and reopen it, and update Excel. Check your licence in your Microsoft 365 account and ask IT if Copilot is disabled for your tenant. Pair with a neighbour meanwhile.
There is no Plan option in the mode menu.	Some Excel builds show only Allow editing and Chat only. Use Chat only, end the prompt with 'Show me the plan; do not change anything yet', then switch to Allow editing to carry it out.
'Unsupported file state' message.	Save as a normal .xlsx (Strict Open XML files are not supported), close and reopen it. If the file is read-only, copy it into work-c34 and open the copy.
Copilot answers about the whole sheet instead of the table.	Mention tblApplications in the prompt and click inside the table before asking.
Copilot's count differs from the Checks sheet.	Ask Copilot how it counted (all rows or unique IDs, which Stage values). Trust the Checks sheet, note the difference and ask again more precisely.

Challenge

Ask Copilot to add a Pipeline_Status column that groups the stages into Active, Hired and Closed (Rejected or Withdrawn). Check that the three counts add up to the row count.

Reflection

Which data-quality issue would most distort a source-effectiveness report if you had not found it, and why?